Study Title: Ubuntu: Expert Survey (IRB26-0962)
Researcher: Julio S. Solis Arce, Harvard University
Faculty Sponsor: Torben Iversen
Version Date: September 8, 2026

What is the purpose of this research?

This study asks scholars and professionals with relevant expertise how Ubuntu is defined, understood, and applied across African languages, societies, and scholarly traditions. We want to learn which parts of a proposed definition are accurate, incomplete, contested, or specific to particular contexts; which related terms and proverbs should be considered; and how the definition and a planned survey measure should be revised. The results will support a conceptual paper and the later development of a measure of Ubuntu.

What can I expect if I take part in this research?

You will complete one online survey through deliberation.io using your own internet-connected device. The full activity is expected to take no more than approximately 15 minutes.

- Answer open-ended questions about Ubuntu, related terms, languages, and proverbs.
- Review the research team's proposed definition of Ubuntu and comment on its elements.
- Take part in up to four brief text-based follow-up questions from an AI facilitator.
- Provide your disciplinary background, nationality, professional location, email address, and additional comments. Your name is required only to verify that you are on the invited expert list; your email address is optional.
- Review and comment on the developing Ubuntu survey instrument.

The platform records your survey responses and, if you use the AI facilitator, the chat conversation. All substantive questions and the AI conversation are optional. You may skip questions, leave the website, or stop at any time before submitting your responses.

What are the possible risks or discomforts?

This study involves no more than minimal risk. Reflecting on cultural identity, spirituality, personhood, or contested interpretations of Ubuntu may cause mild discomfort, if any. Online data collection also carries a small risk of unauthorized access or interception.

Are there benefits, costs, or compensation?

You should not expect any direct personal benefit from participating.

How will my information be protected and used?

The survey collects your responses and name and, if you choose to provide them, professional or demographic background information and an email address. Identifiable raw responses will be restricted to authorized study personnel. Data will be transmitted through HTTPS and exported by the Principal Investigator through authenticated administrator access to Harvard-approved encrypted storage. Your name and the verification file will be separated from the analytic data as soon as practicable. Direct identifiers and the linkage key will be securely deleted after required verification and study recordkeeping are complete.

Reports and publications may include de-identified summaries and quotations. Your name will not be attached to a quotation unless you separately agree to attribution. Although reasonable safeguards will be used, complete confidentiality cannot be guaranteed.

The de-identified information may be retained and used for this study, related publications, and future research on Ubuntu and scale development without asking for your additional informed consent. Any sharing outside the Harvard study team will use data reviewed to remove direct identifiers and reduce the risk that a participant could be identified.

Deliberation.io platform and use of AI

Deliberation.io is a free, open-source platform developed by researchers at Stanford University and MIT to support online dialogue through surveys and an AI facilitator. In this study, the facilitator ('chatbot') uses an OpenAI model through the OpenAI API to ask neutral follow-up questions based on your responses. Although safeguards are in place, it may occasionally produce irrelevant, inaccurate, or insensitive content. The facilitator does not receive your name, contact details, or other directly identifying information.

Deliberation.io stores your responses during data collection and deletes them when data collection ends. OpenAI does not use API prompts or responses to train its models because data sharing is disabled.

What should I know about taking part?

- Whether or not you take part is up to you.
- Your participation is completely voluntary.
- You can choose not to take part.
- You can agree to take part and later change your mind.
- Your decision will not be held against you.
- Refusing to participate will not result in any consequences.
- You may stop at any time before submitting your responses. Information already collected may be retained when necessary to protect the integrity of the research or comply with legal or institutional requirements.
- Your decision of whether to participate in this study will not impact your relationship with the PI

Who can I talk to?

If you have questions, concerns, or complaints about the research, contact Julio S. Solis Arce at jsolisarce@g.harvard.edu. For questions about your rights as a research participant, contact the Harvard University Area Committee on the Use of Human Subjects at cuhs@harvard.edu.

How do I indicate my consent?

No separate signed consent form or signature will be obtained. By voluntarily proceeding with and completing the survey, you confirm that you are at least 18 years old, have read and understood this information, and consent to participate in the research.